

Semora User Manual

Design a semester you won't regret. See the hard weeks before they hit you.

Semora helps you design a course combination, finalize it, and navigate the resulting semester. It follows one lifecycle:

PLAN -> LOCK -> NAVIGATE

This manual describes the current implementation. Some screens use local deterministic extraction and heuristic workload estimates, so Semora always distinguishes confirmed information from estimates and asks you to review extracted course data before it affects the active semester.

1. Create an account

1. Open the Semora web app.
2. Choose **Create account**.
3. Enter your email and password.
4. Sign in when prompted.

Your session is stored through the application authentication flow. Use **Sign out** from the application navigation when you are finished.

2. Start a semester workspace

The **Plan** screen is the starting point for semester design.

1. Create a semester workspace.
2. Choose the available term.
3. Enter or confirm your planning preferences.
4. Use the catalogue search to find course offerings.

Semora keeps candidate semesters separate. You can create alternatives without overwriting the others.

3. Build a candidate semester

For each candidate:

1. Search by course code or title.
2. Open a course to inspect sections and meetings.
3. Select the section you want to consider.
4. Watch the credit total and timetable update.

5. Repeat until the candidate represents a realistic semester.

Semora treats overlapping class meetings as hard conflicts. Back-to-back meetings are allowed when one ends exactly as the next begins. An invalid candidate can still be inspected, but it should not be treated as a normal recommendation.

4. Add commitments

Coursework is only part of a semester. Add commitments such as a TAsip, society, job, commute, research, gym schedule, or recurring personal obligation.

For a commitment, provide:

- * a name and category;
- * recurring time blocks when the commitment has fixed hours;
- * estimated weekly effort;
- * optional one-off high-intensity dates;
- * a flexibility level.

Use the flexibility level intentionally:

- * **Hard:** an overlap is a feasibility problem.
- * **Soft:** an overlap is a penalty or warning.
- * **Flexible:** the commitment can move and should not invalidate the candidate by itself.

If one real-world obligation contains both fixed and flexible parts, record them as separate commitments so Semora can model them honestly.

5. Set priorities and course preferences

Semora does not assume that the lowest workload is always best. Choose the trade-offs that matter to you, such as:

- * lower overall workload;
- * compact schedules or free days;
- * fewer early or late classes;
- * project or exam preference;
- * career relevance;
- * personal interest;
- * assessment safety and balance.

The course inputs you provide manually

For each course offering, you can save a workload profile and course-fit ratings. These are manual estimates and preferences, not facts that Semora can reliably infer from a catalogue.

Workload dimensions use a 0-10 scale. Higher means heavier modeled demand:

- * **Overall intensity:** your estimate of the course's total academic demand.
- * **Continuous workload:** the amount of ongoing work throughout the term rather than only a few large exams.
- * **Assignment intensity:** the regular assignment or homework burden.
- * **Quiz intensity:** the frequency or burden of quizzes and short tests.
- * **Project intensity:** the size, complexity, or coordination burden of projects.
- * **Exam intensity:** the expected importance or preparation burden of midterms and finals.
- * **Lab intensity:** the practical, lab, or hands-on workload.
- * **Reading intensity:** the expected reading load.
- * **Schedule burden:** how awkward or time-consuming the meeting pattern is.
- * **Assessment fragmentation:** how spread out or numerous the assessment demands feel.

You may also enter estimated hours per week. Leaving a field blank means unknown. Semora may begin with a structural estimate where one exists, but you can replace it with your own estimate or reset it later. The saved profile belongs to that course offering in this workspace and is reused by candidate comparisons.

For course fit, choose **Interest** and **Career relevance** as Low, Medium, or High. Interest means how much you personally want to study the subject. Career relevance means how strongly the course supports your academic or career direction. These ratings are also manual, and they are reused across candidate semesters.

These values are signals, not hard constraints. They influence explanations and recommendation tags rather than silently deciding for you.

6. Read candidate intelligence

For a candidate, review:

- * validity and credit totals;
- * schedule quality and burden;
- * academic and continuous workload;
- * project and exam concentration;
- * commitment compatibility;
- * interest and career fit;
- * balance, completeness, confidence, and findings.

Open the **Why?** explanations when a score or metric is unclear. Semora uses directional language carefully: some metrics are better when lower, while fit and balance metrics are better when higher.

Structured findings identify causes rather than just assigning a number. Examples include a timetable clash, a long day, project concentration, or a commitment overlap.

7. Compare candidates

Use the comparison view to inspect candidates side by side. Look for meaningful differences instead of treating tiny score changes as decisive.

A recommendation tag is a preference-sensitive summary, not an objective verdict. For example, one candidate may have stronger career fit but higher project concentration, while another may offer a lighter and more compact week.

Use bounded scenario exploration to try a temporary change without saving it into the candidate. Scenarios are previews; they do not replace the saved selection or preferences until you explicitly make a real change.

8. Lock the semester

When one candidate is ready:

1. Review the selected sections, timetable, commitments, and major trade-offs.
2. Choose **Lock semester**.
3. Confirm the transition.

Locking makes the selected courses the active semester while preserving planning data. During Add/Drop, you can add, switch, or drop active courses without losing the candidate history.

After locking, the home view changes from semester design toward active-semester navigation. You can still add, edit, or remove commitments after locking, and Add/Drop still supports adding, switching, or dropping active courses.

9. Add course outlines

For an active course, attach a course outline when you have one.

Supported development workflow inputs include PDF, DOCX, and plain text. The current provider is deterministic and local; it is not an external LLM service.

1. Open the active course.
2. Upload the outline.
3. Wait for the extraction job to finish.
4. Choose **Review extraction**.

The extraction draft may identify course identity, instructors, grading categories, assessments, dates, weights, thresholds, aggregation rules, and warnings. It may also leave fields unknown. Unknown is safer than an invented value.

10. Review and verify extracted data

Treat the review page as a required checkpoint.

1. Confirm the course code and title match the active course.
2. Correct instructor names if necessary.
3. Review grading mode and category weights.
4. Review each assessment, type, date, weight, and category.
5. Resolve blocking conflicts, such as a course mismatch, impossible totals, invalid dates, or unresolved aggregation parameters.
6. Expand grouped assessments when the source gives an exact count and the category supports equal weighting. For example, an exact "Four programming assignments" line can be expanded into four equal, individually trackable items during review.
7. Add missing information manually when the outline does not provide it.
8. Choose **Verify** only when the draft represents the course accurately.

Verification promotes the reviewed draft into canonical academic data. Workload and grade calculations consume verified or manually entered data, not an unreviewed extraction draft.

If extraction is incomplete, use manual assessment entry. The product should remain usable even when one outline is unusual or unreadable.

An approximate range such as "5-6 quizzes" is not a special range object in the current model. Do not treat an automatically extracted result as a confirmed count; correct the review draft manually, keep it grouped, or add the individual quiz slots once you know them. An exact total of N quizzes is enough to create N quiz slots, but it does not resolve a separate unknown drop count X. If the outline says "N quizzes; X may be dropped" and X has not been declared, Semora cannot encode that as an optional 0-or-more drop rule, so verification must wait until X is known. If X is 0, use Equal weight; if X is positive, configure Drop lowest X. The DROP_LOWEST_N and BEST_N configurations require a positive integer parameter. If the total quiz count is known but the individual records are not entered yet, expand the exact count during review and add dates or scores later.

11. Navigate the active semester

The active-semester command center answers:

- * What matters now?
- * What is due soon?
- * How heavy is the current week?
- * When is the next pressure peak?
- * Which assessments and commitments cause that pressure?

Use the dashboard sections to inspect:

- * due-soon work and priorities;
- * current and upcoming daily pressure;
- * weekly pressure findings;
- * the full-term pressure heatmap;
- * the assessment timeline;
- * course grade cards and remaining work.

Higher pressure means more modeled demand. Pressure bands and findings explain the window and related assessments rather than pretending to be exact predictions of the number of hours you will need.

What works before assessment dates are known?

Dates are useful, but they are not required for Semora's core academic state. Before dates are available, you can still:

- * keep the assessment in the timeline with its title, type, category, and weight;
- * review category weights and grade calculations;
- * enter scores and class statistics when results are available;
- * track progress and mark work complete;
- * use current performance, remaining weight, target-grade, drop-rule, and what-if calculations;
- * keep workload effort estimates and commitment pressure available;
- * add or correct assessments as the instructor reveals them.

Known dates add the time dimension. They enable due-soon ordering, urgency, preparation windows, deadline compression, dated overlap findings, daily and weekly pressure placement, and the heatmap. An assessment without a date is retained and contributes to non-temporal information such as effort, importance when its weight is known, remaining work, and confidence/completeness, but it is not placed on a particular day or week. Semora reports the missing date instead of inventing one.

Surprise quizzes do not need a special feature. Add the quiz manually with no date, record progress or mark it done, and add the date later if it becomes known. Leaving the date blank is valid; marking the work done does not require a date.

12. Manage assessments

Assessments can come from verified outline data or manual entry. Each assessment keeps academic result state separate from work-progress state.

You can:

- * search and filter the timeline by course and assessment type;
- * edit title, type, date, weight, category, and effort estimate;
- * move a deadline or mark a date unknown;

- * mark work complete;
- * record a score when the result is available.

Changing a deadline or completion state recalculates the active pressure forecast. Completing work removes its future dated pressure contribution while retaining the historical assessment record. You can mark an undated assessment done without entering a date; it simply has no dated pressure contribution to remove.

Most of the manual setup happens when the semester begins or when course information becomes available: entering course workload/fit estimates, uploading and verifying outlines, and correcting the initial assessment structure. During the term, the usual maintenance is much smaller: add newly announced dates, update progress, mark work done, enter scores, and occasionally add, edit, cancel, or remove an assessment when the course changes.

13. Understand grades

The Grade Dashboard uses deterministic calculations.

For a course, review:

- * current performance;
- * weighted points earned;
- * graded and remaining weight;
- * current absolute grade equivalent when thresholds are confirmed;
- * required average across remaining work for a target;
- * whether a target is mathematically reachable;
- * temporary what-if projections.

What-if values are previews only. They do not change saved scores.

Categories may use equal mean, points weighting, individual weights, best N, or drop-lowest N rules. The dashboard explains the selected rule and preserves the distinction between stored weights and derived equal shares.

For relative grading, Semora can show safe class-statistics context such as difference from the mean and standardized position when the data is sufficient. It does not fabricate a letter-grade prediction from incomplete relative information.

14. Read uncertainty correctly

Semora combines different kinds of information:

- * official catalogue and timetable data;
- * user-entered preferences and estimates;
- * outline-derived drafts;
- * user-verified canonical academic data;

* deterministic calculations.

These are not equally certain. A missing final date remains unknown. A heuristic workload estimate is not the same as a verified assessment weight. Use the confidence and completeness explanations to decide what deserves manual follow-up.

Unknown dates reduce the confidence of the time-based forecast; they do not disable the rest of the course or grade intelligence. The heatmap and dated pressure findings become more useful incrementally as dates are added during the term.

15. Common recovery paths

A course outline fails

Retry the extraction, upload a clearer file, or enter assessments manually. A failed extraction should not prevent active-semester planning.

A course mismatch appears

Check that the outline belongs to the selected course and offering. Do not verify a document against the wrong course.

A grading total is invalid

Review duplicate categories, missing rule parameters, or weights that exceed a valid total. Correct the draft before verification.

A date is unknown

Leave it unknown until you have reliable information. The workload engine excludes unknown dates from time-based calculations rather than inventing a date.

A TAship has fixed and flexible work

Use two commitments when the parts behave differently. Create one recurring **HARD** commitment for fixed office hours, and a second **FLEXIBLE** or **SOFT** commitment for grading, preparation, or assessment-writing work. Give the second record its expected weekly hours and use one-off events when a particular grading or preparation block gets a known date. Flexibility applies to the whole commitment record, so splitting these parts keeps the model honest.

The dashboard looks heavy

Open the pressure finding or heatmap week. Inspect the related assessments, commitments, and completion states. Move a deadline only when the real academic information changed.

The candidate is invalid

Inspect timetable and commitment clashes first, then review credits and selected sections. A scenario can help test a replacement without changing the saved candidate.

16. Current product boundaries

Semora currently does not:

- * automatically register courses;
- * generate a complete study plan or timetable for you;
- * act as a general calendar, notes, or document-chat application;
- * consume unverified extraction as canonical truth;
- * predict exact final grades from insufficient data;
- * provide production external-AI extraction in the local baseline;
- * provide community workload intelligence or predictive ML in V1.

Those boundaries keep the product explainable and keep the user in control of academic truth.